IMEN891K / IDSC501 / AXGS-501 · DATA ENGINEERING · FALL 2026

3.

Data Exploration

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Industrial & Management Engineering

Where We Are

Part I (Lec 2–5): collection, exploration, and preprocessing



You cannot clean what you have not looked at

Outline: Data Exploration

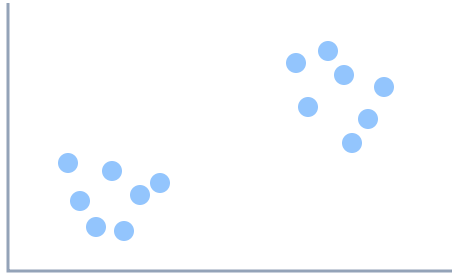
01

Descriptive Analysis

Reduce the data to a few numbers

02

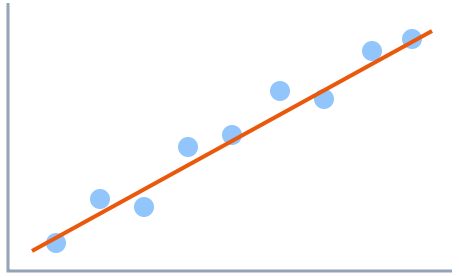
Visual Exploration



Find patterns by plotting the data

03

Statistical Exploration



Read relationships between variables

Three Ways to Read One Table

Numbers, pictures, relations: what each of today's three parts produces

$\bar{x}$ s Σ **Numbers**	Summarize location, spread and distribution shape	PART 1 **Descriptive Analysis**
Pictures	Choose plots that reveal structure and time patterns	PART 2 **Visual Exploration**
Relations	What ties two columns, and whether it is a cause	PART 3 **Statistical Exploration**

Descriptive Analysis

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Statistical Exploration

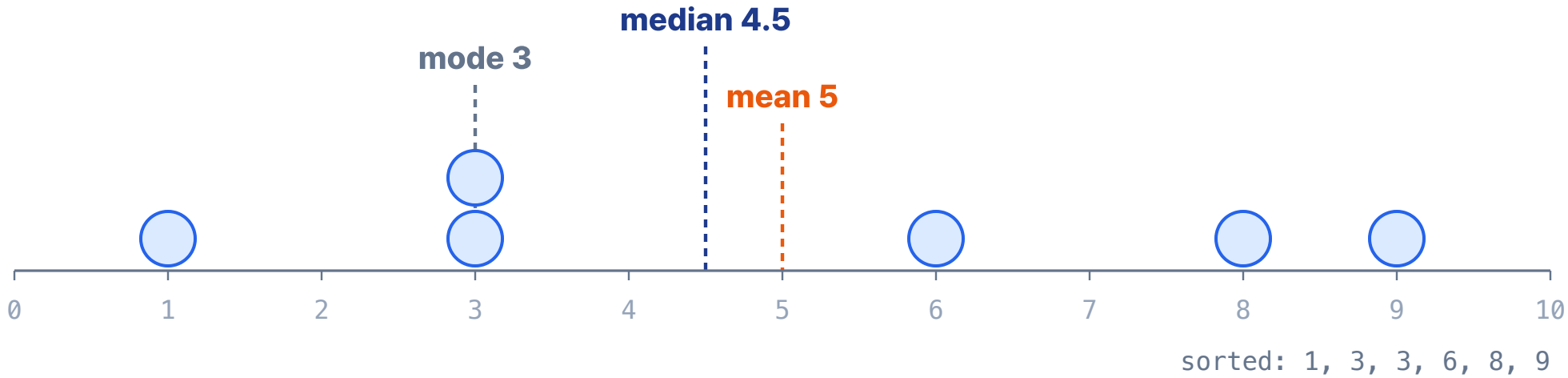
Read relationships between variables

Central Tendency



Recap: Mean, Median, Mode

Three answers to “the typical value”

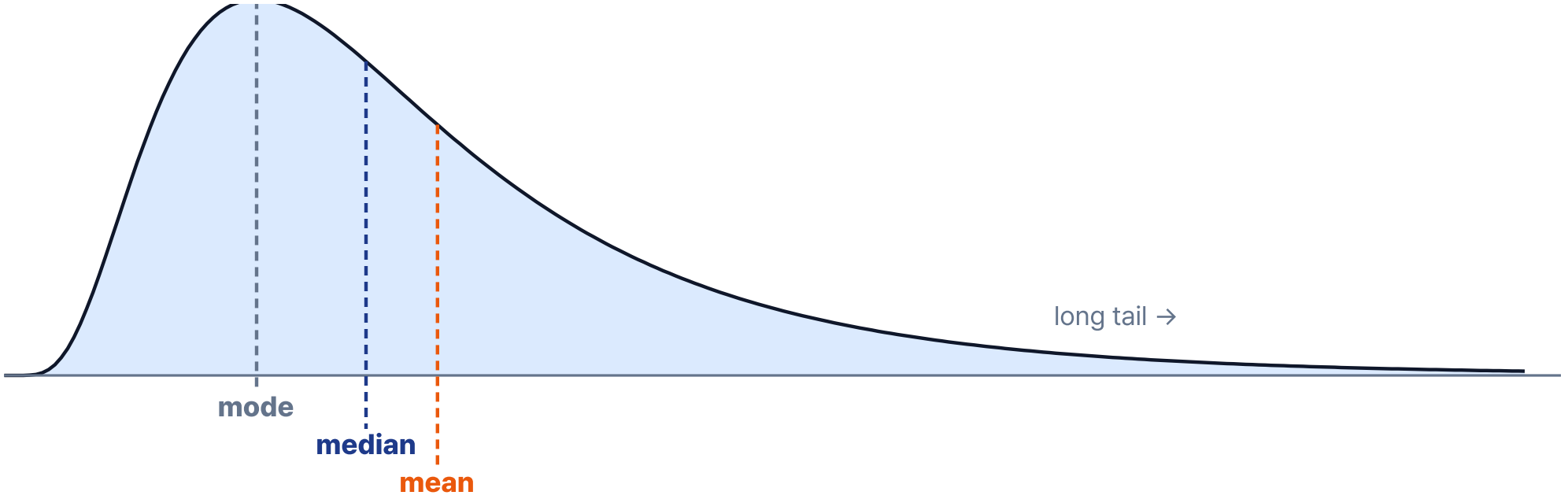


MEAN $\bar{x} = (1/n) \sum_i x_i$ | MEDIAN $(x_{(n/2)} + x_{(n/2+1)}) / 2$ | MODE $\text{argmax}_x \text{ count}(x)$

From 9, 3, 1, 8, 3, 6: mean **5**, median **4.5**, mode **3**

Skew and the Three Centers

Mode at the peak, median in the middle, mean pulled into the tail

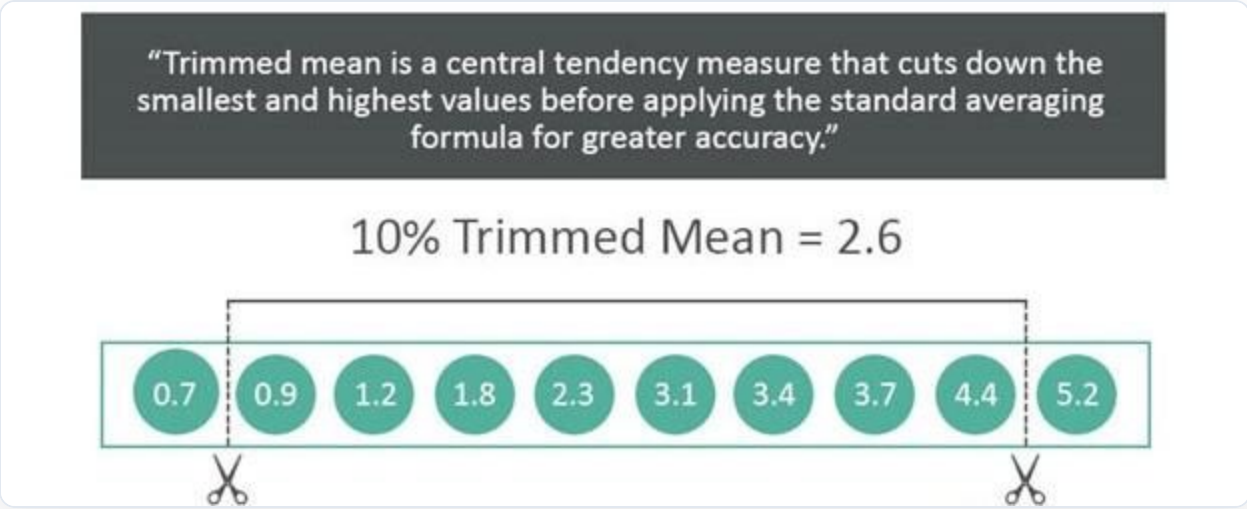


`nonparametric skew = (x̄ − median) / s` positive when the long tail runs right

Only the mean follows the tail, so **mean minus median tells you which way the data leans**

Trimmed Mean

Drop a fixed share from each end and an outlier stops pulling the mean



$$\bar{x}_\alpha = (1 / (n - 2k)) \sum_{i=k+1}^{n-k} x_{(i)}, \quad k = \lfloor \alpha n \rfloor$$ α = 0 is the mean, α → ½ is the median

Cut the ends and a far-out row stops counting, **while every row in the middle still does**

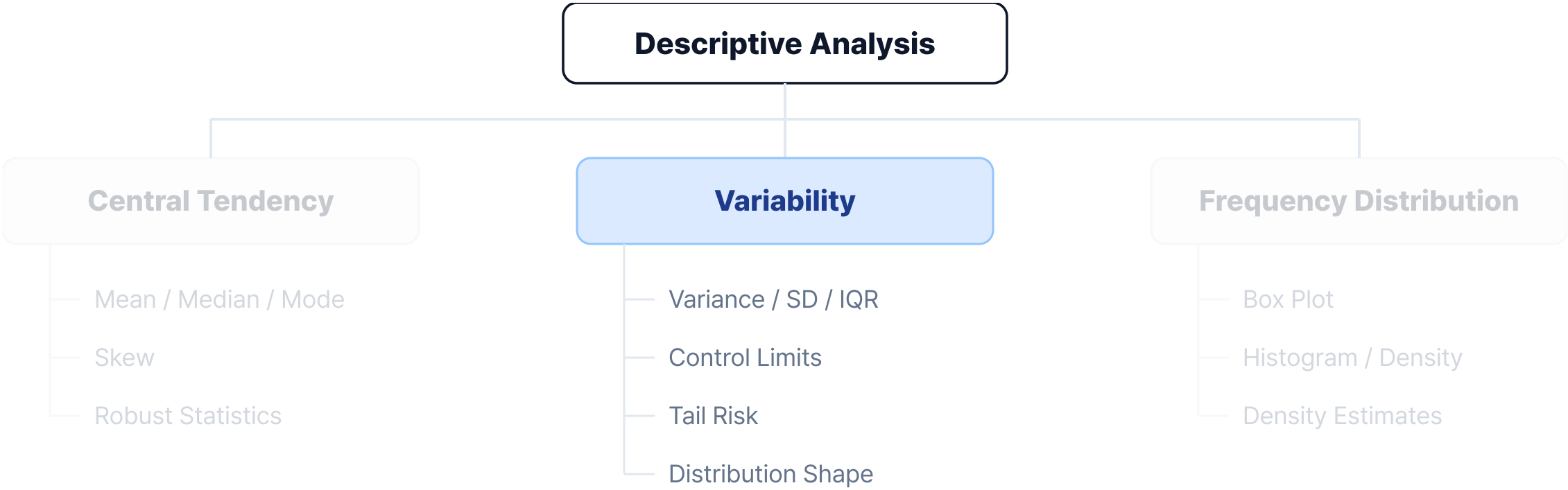
Robust Statistics

Every summary comes in a version built to ignore the far end

WHAT YOU SUMMARIZE	READS EVERY VALUE	READS ONLY THE MIDDLE
Center	**Mean** one far row moves it	**Median** trimmed mean sits between them
Spread	**Standard deviation** squares every distance first	**IQR, MAD** interquartile range, median absolute deviation

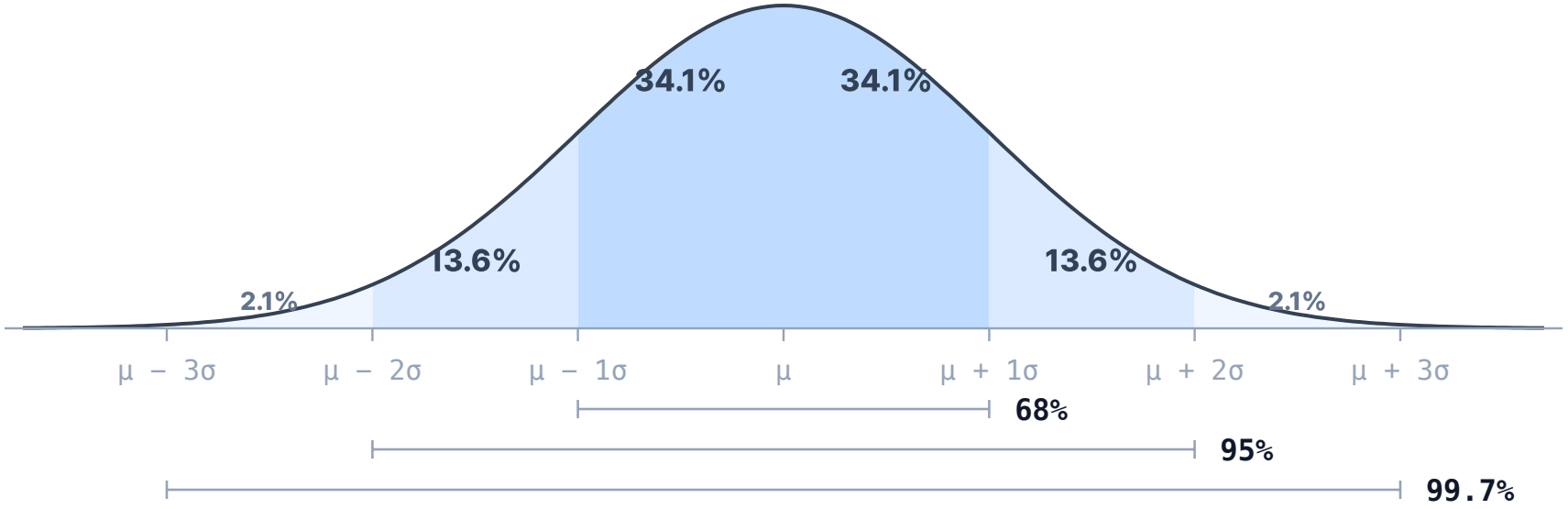
The split is not about the mean: **every summary number has both versions**

Variability



Recap: Standard Deviation

The 68–95–99.7 rule

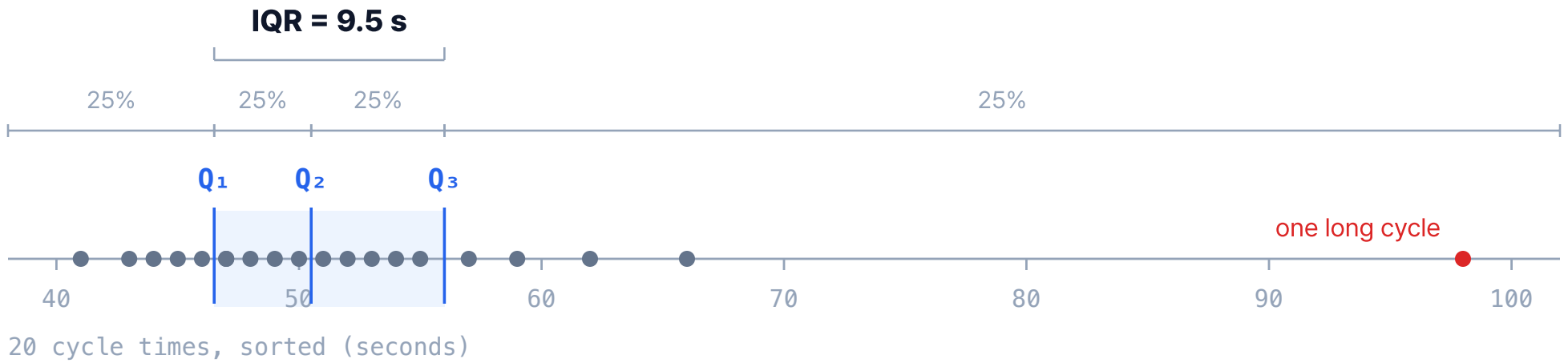


$$s = \sqrt{\ (1/(n-1))\ \sum_i\ (x_i - \bar{x})^2\ }$$ the square is what lets one far-out row dominate

These percentages hold for a normal distribution **and only then**

Interquartile Range (IQR)

Q3 − Q1, the width of the middle half: it does not care how far the outlier sits

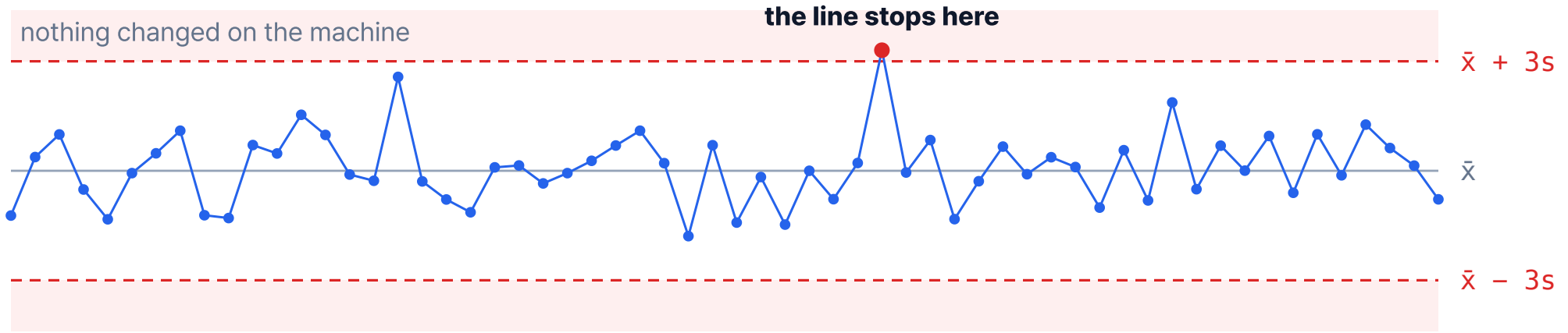


$$IQR = Q_3 - Q_1$$ Q_1, Q_3 are the 25th and 75th percentiles

Every cut holds the same number of rows, **so how far the last one sits changes nothing**

Control Limits and the Normal Curve

A normal curve puts about 0.27% of its mass outside μ ± 3σ

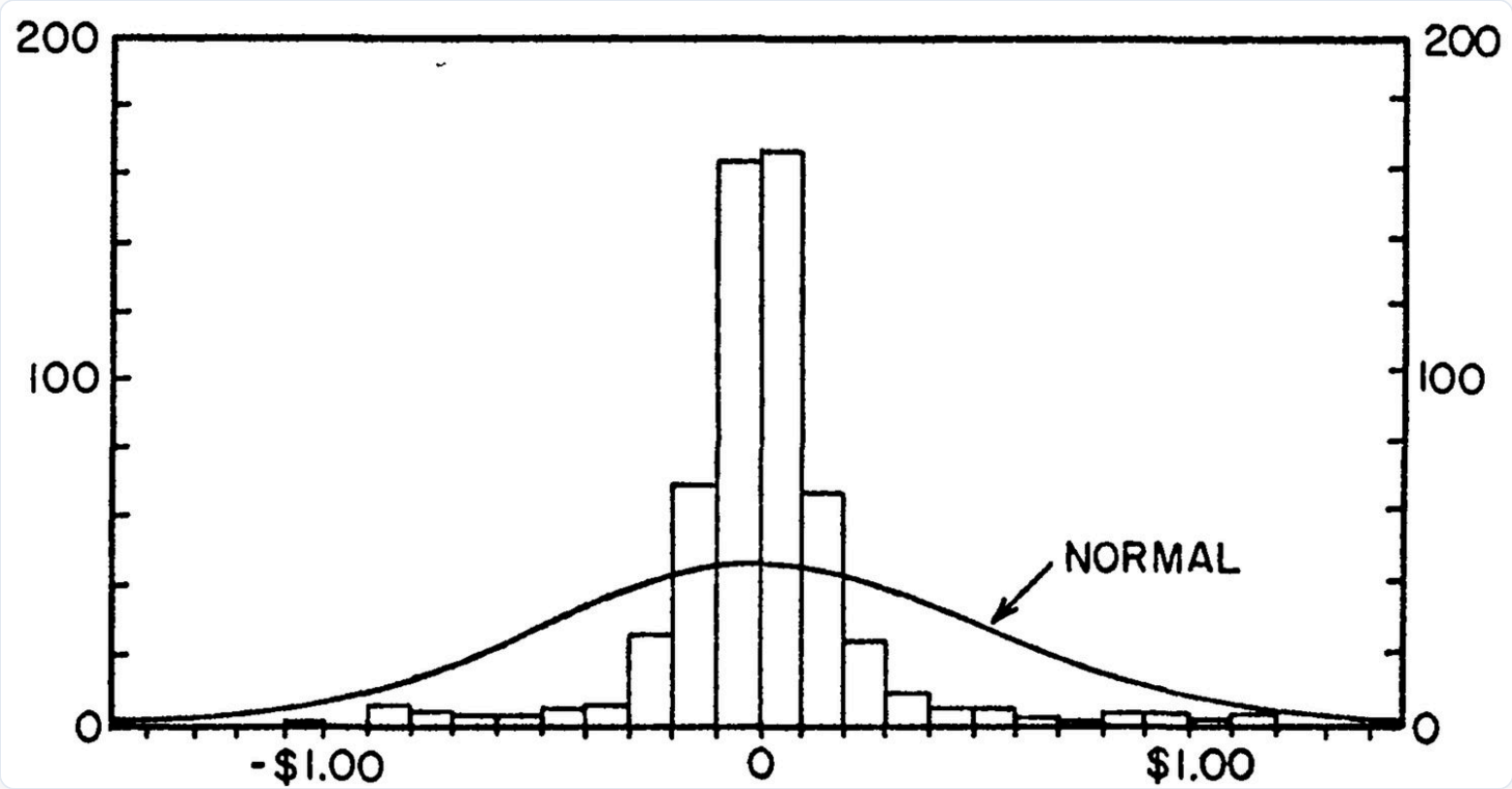


bearing temperature, one reading per hour

0.27% assumes a normal distribution with known parameters; estimated limits can behave differently

Case study: Heavy Tails in Price Changes

Mandelbrot, 1963: the risk models of the day assumed Gaussian moves



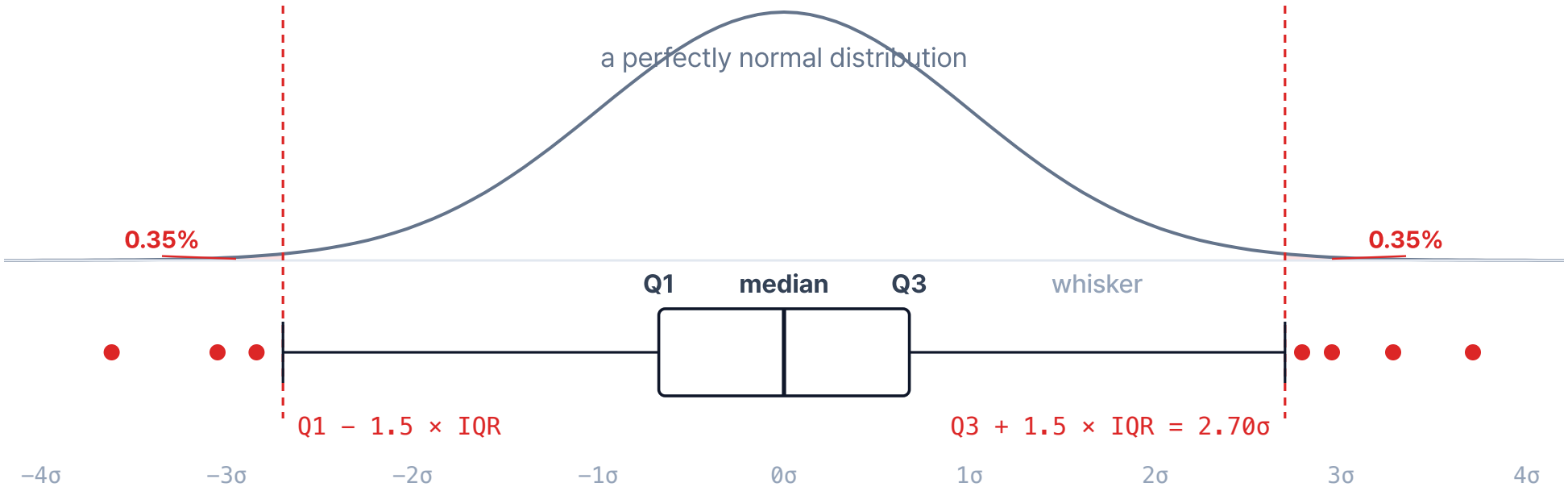
Quieter than Gaussian on most days, and **far wilder on the rare ones**

Frequency Distribution



Box Plot

The 1.5×IQR whisker rule flags 0.7% of perfectly normal data as outliers

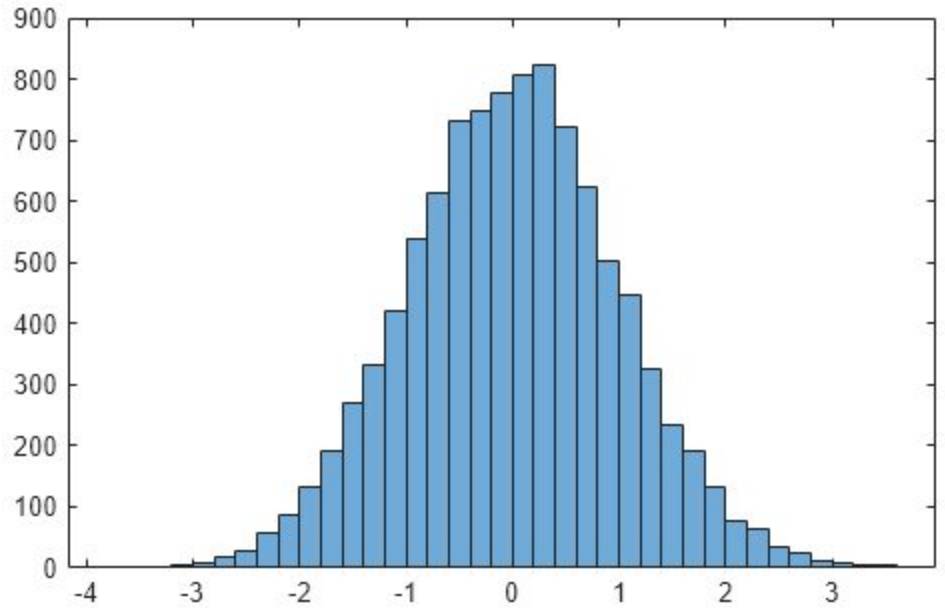


$$\text{IQR} = Q_3 - Q_1 \quad | \quad \text{fences at } Q_1 - 1.5 \cdot \text{IQR} \text{ and } Q_3 + 1.5 \cdot \text{IQR}$$

The orange dots are ordinary draws from the curve above, **and the fences flag every one of them**

Histogram as Empirical Distribution

To see the whole shape, stop summarizing and count: the empirical distribution



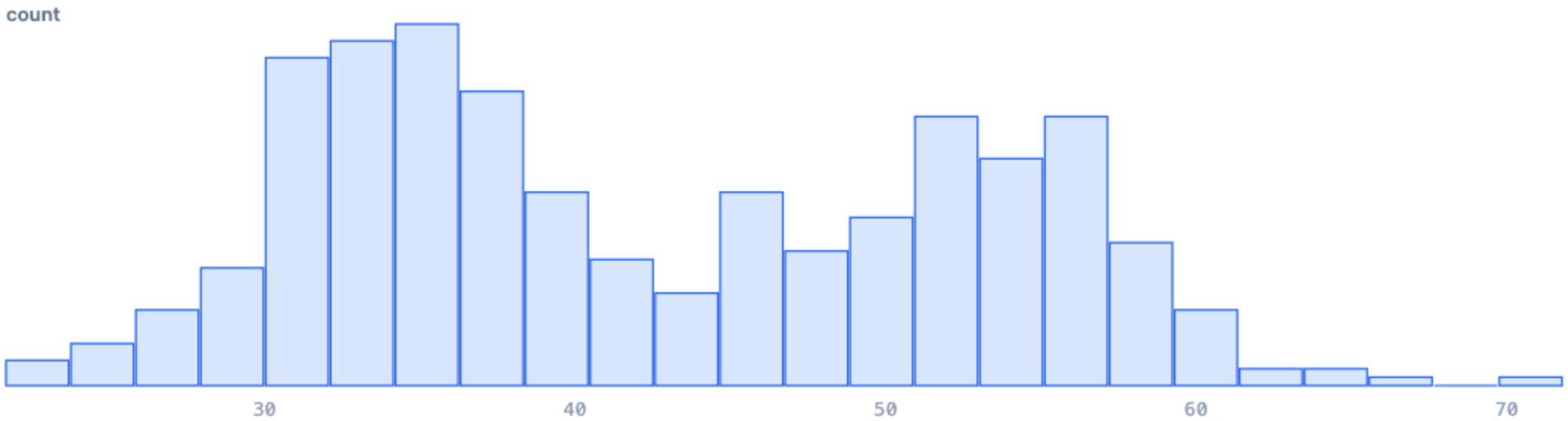
Split the range into bins and count. **No summary number is used at all**

Demo: Histogram Bin Count

Same 420 numbers, bin count is the only thing changing

1. Compare 4, 24 and 70 bins. 2. Which pattern survives your choices?

Bins 24 Reset



bin width **2.09** · tallest bin sits at **35.3**

Answer: Histogram Choices

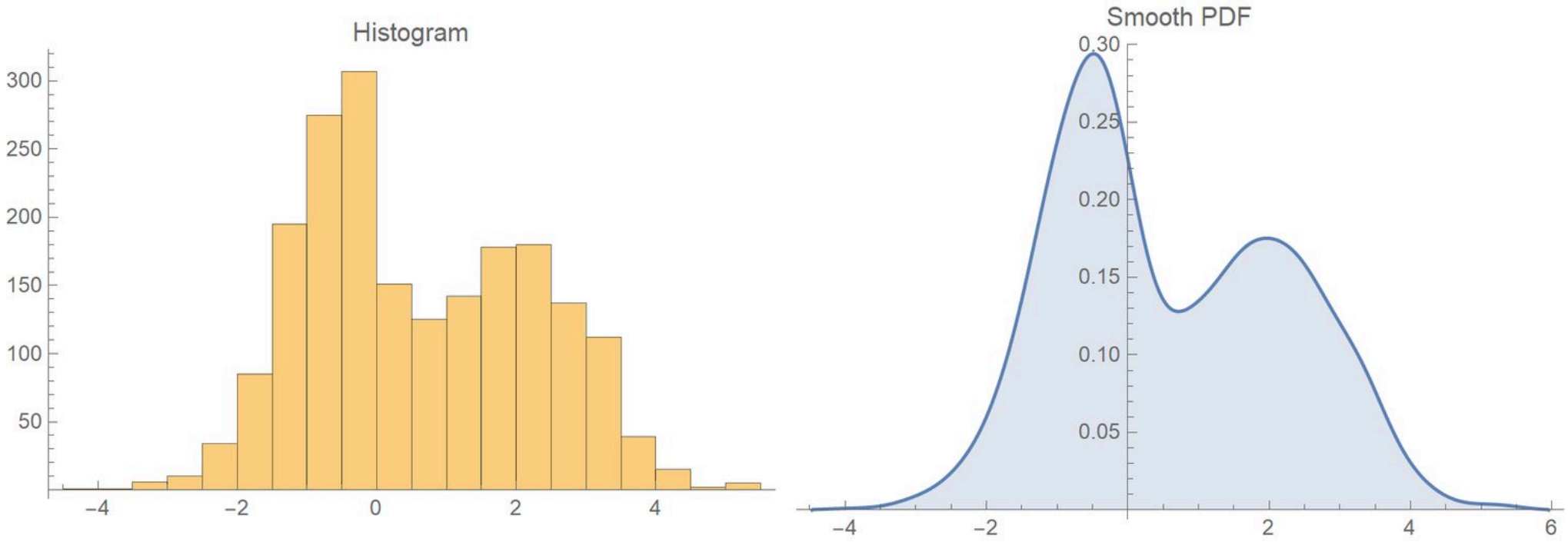
Read what changed before choosing a setting

Setting	Interpretation
Few bins	Distinct peaks can merge
Many bins	Sparse bars can mimic structure
Several settings	Report stable distribution features

The setting changes the picture; the underlying data stay fixed

Kernel Density Estimation (KDE)

Smoothing the histogram trades bin count for bandwidth



$$\hat{f}(x) = (1/nh) \sum_i K\left(\frac{x - x_i}{h}\right)$$ K is the kernel, h the bandwidth

A small kernel on every point, summed. **The choice moves from bin count to bandwidth**

Visual Exploration

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Statistical Exploration

Read relationships between variables

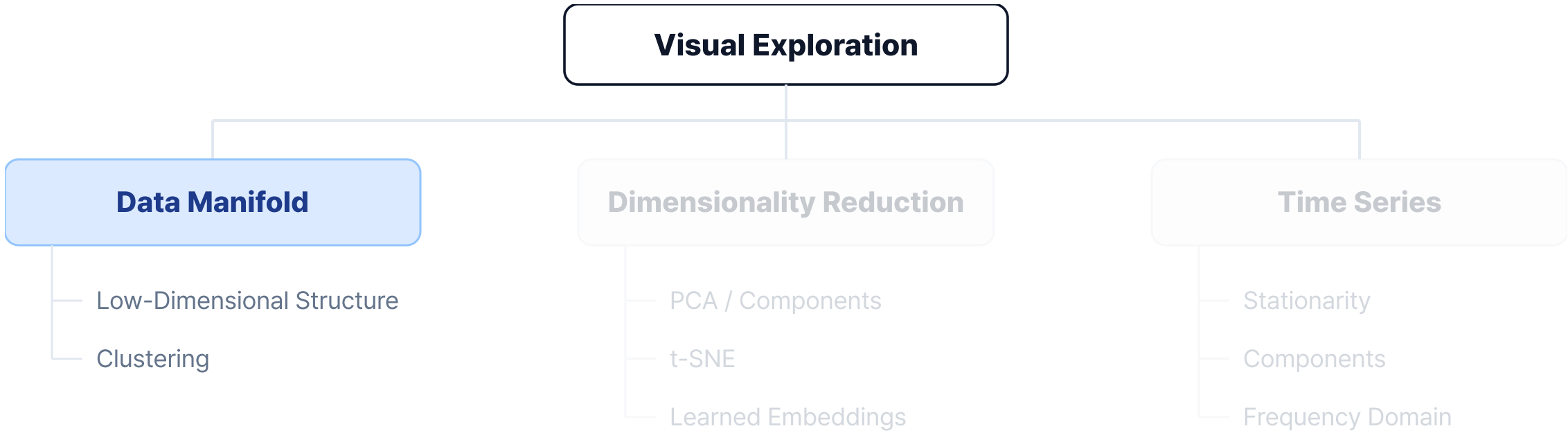
Recap: Five Standard Charts

The five you already know

 Which category is bigger?	BAR CHART
 How does the whole split up?	PIE OR STACKED BAR
Which values are common?	HISTOGRAM, BOX PLOT
 Do these two move together?	SCATTER PLOT
 What changed over time?	LINE CHART

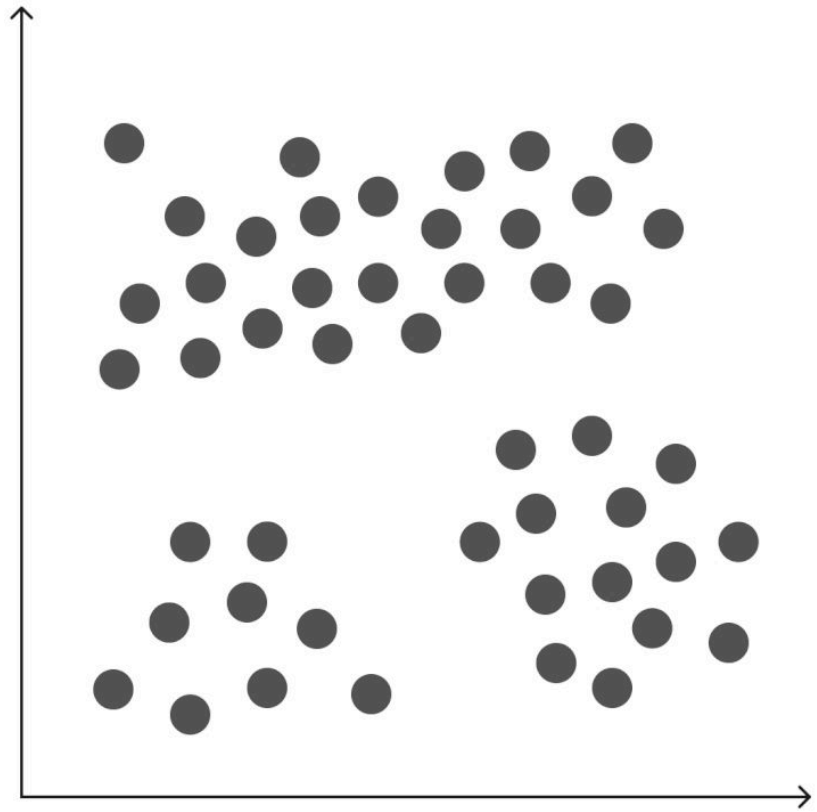
Every one of these needs you to **already know which columns matter**

Data Manifold



Data Manifold

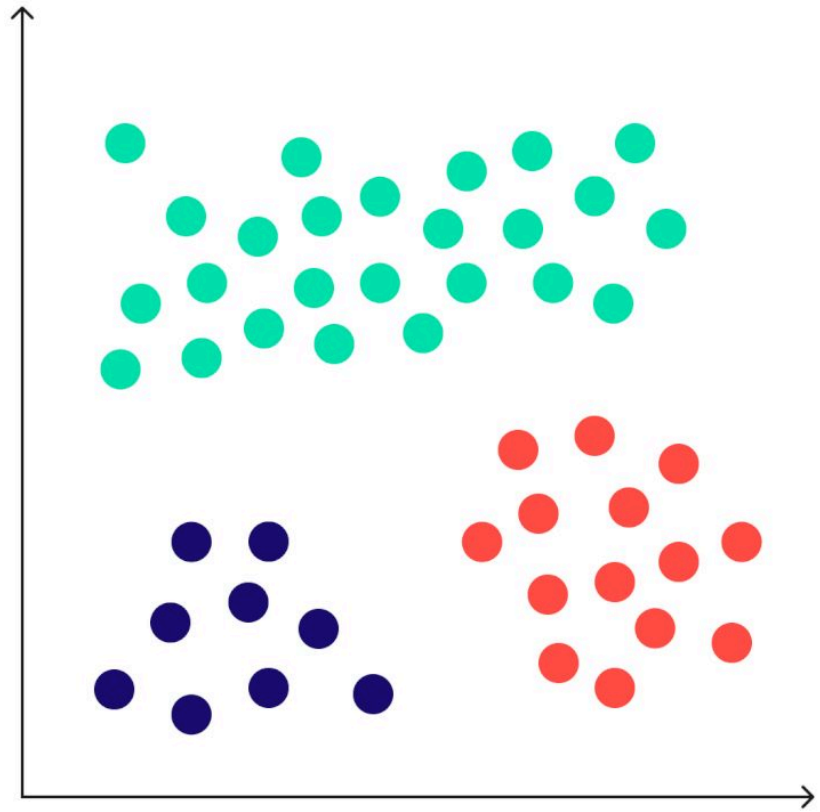
Data does not fill the space evenly: it sits on a thinner structure inside it



Most of the space is empty: the points sit on a **much thinner structure** inside it

Clustering with k-means

It always returns groups: the same points after asking k-means for three



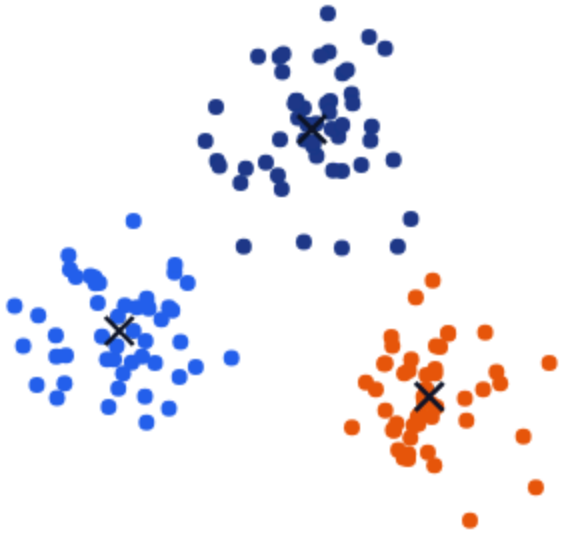
Ask for three and you get three, structure or not. **k is the bin width of clustering**

Demo: k-means Clustering

Same 150 points every time, k is the only input k-means gets

1. Compare k = 2, 3 and 6. 2. Can the smallest WCSS select k?

k 3 Reset



k = **3** · this matches the **three groups that are actually there** · within-cluster sum of squares **120**, which only ever falls as k grows, so it cannot pick k for you.

Answer: Cluster Count

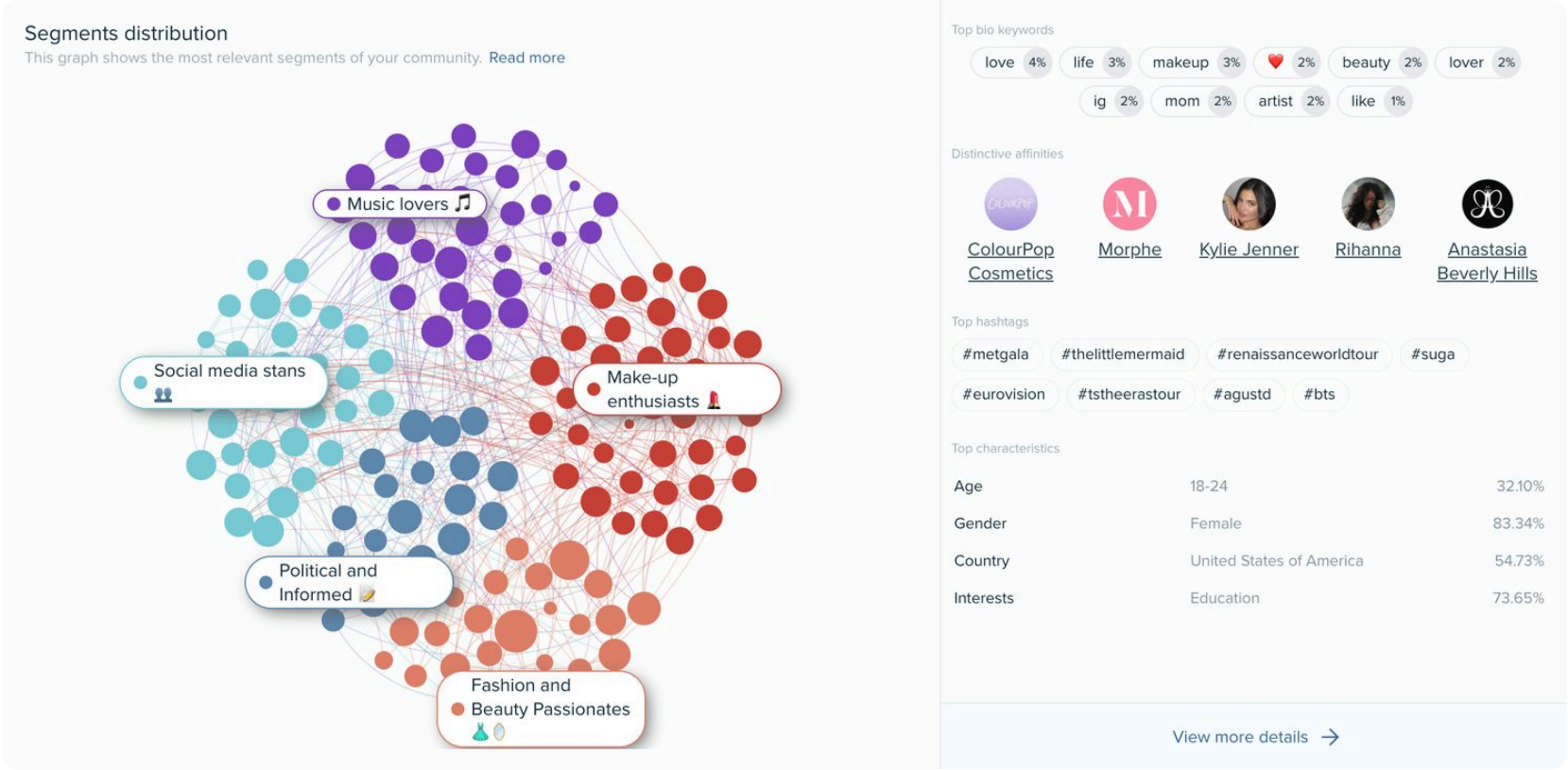
Read what changed before choosing a setting

Setting	Interpretation
k = 2	Groups merge
k = 3	Three groups in this synthetic example
k = 6	Groups split; WCSS can still fall

The setting changes the picture; the underlying data stay fixed

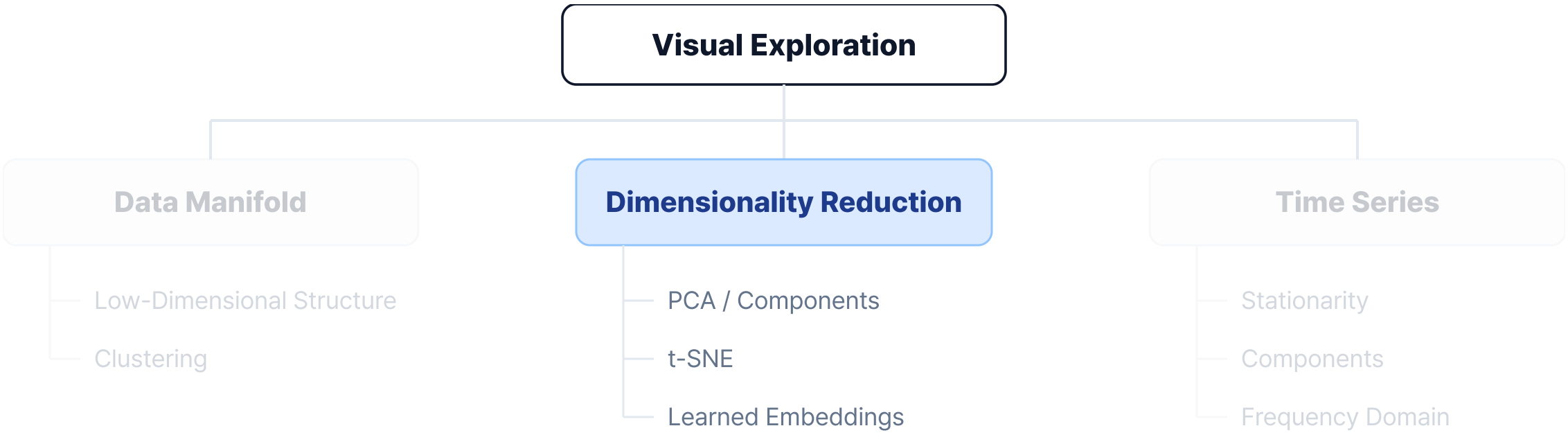
Case study: Marketing Segmentation

A cluster needs a name to be useful: from a cluster number to a readable persona



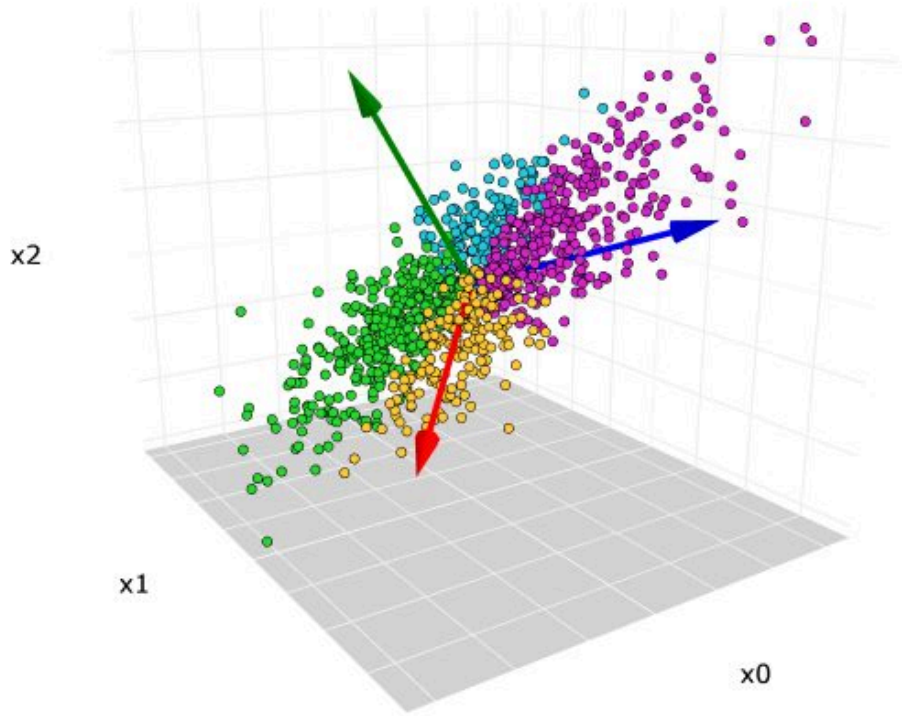
A cluster number is useless until someone can say **what makes that group different**

Dimensionality Reduction



Principal Component Analysis (PCA)

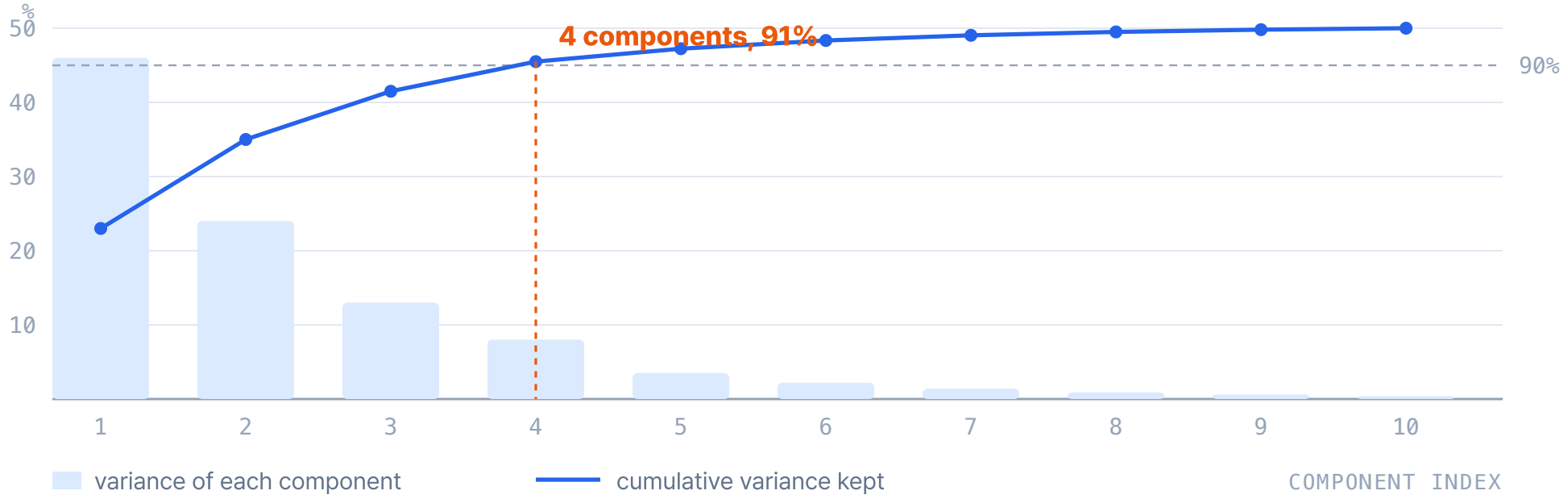
Rotate the axes so the spread lands on the first few



The three arrows are the new axes. **The longest one points along the widest spread**

Choosing the Number of Components

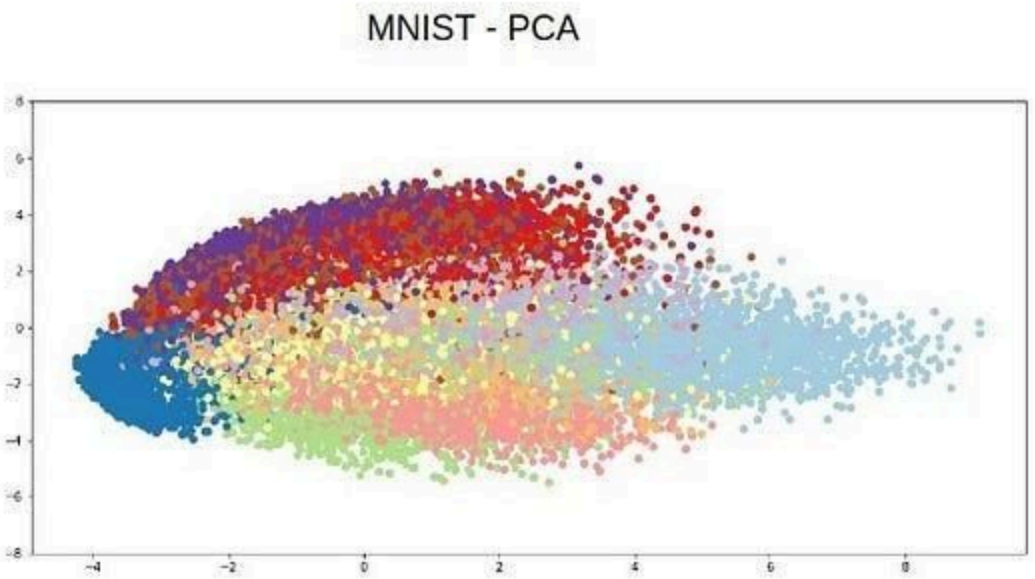
Keep components until the curve flattens: the r-th eigenvalue is the variance the r-th component keeps

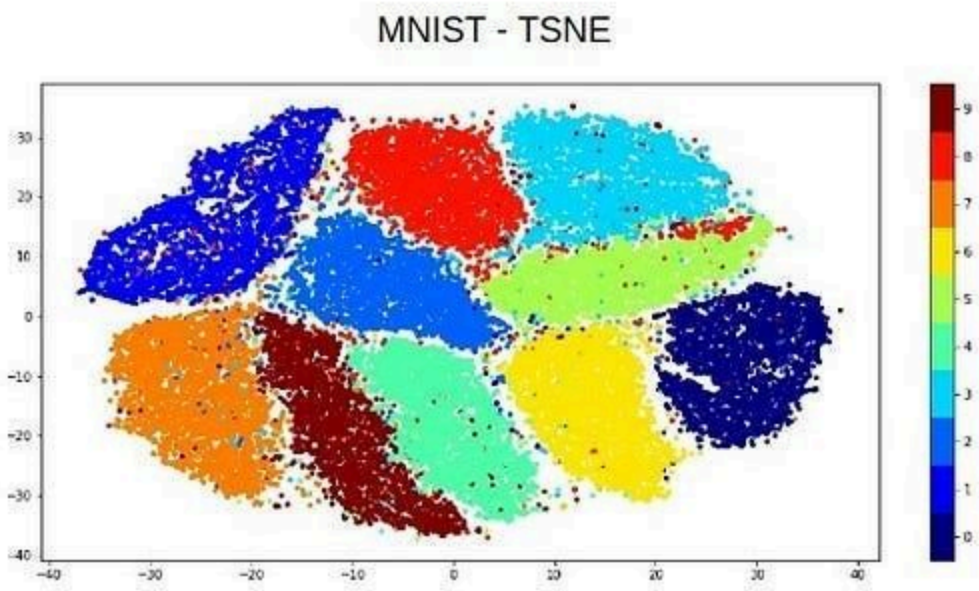


Four of ten carry 91% here. **The 90% line is a convention, not a criterion**

t-SNE vs PCA

t-distributed stochastic neighbor embedding separates what PCA leaves overlapping





The same digits, twice: **the classes overlap on the left and separate on the right**

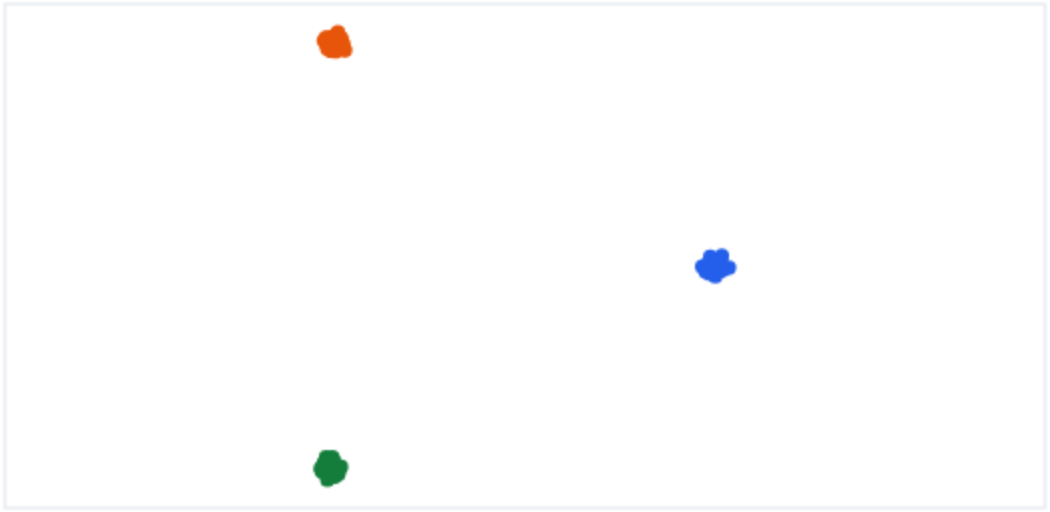
Demo: t-SNE Perplexity

Same two datasets every time, only the perplexity moves

1. Compare perplexity 2 and 30. 2. Can a visible island prove a real cluster?

Perplexity 30 default Reset

three real groups



no groups at all, pure noise



perplexity **30** · the **default in scikit-learn and openTSNE**. The effective neighborhood size is about 30: the left settles into **three**, the right into **one cloud**.

Perplexity is roughly how many neighbors each point is asked to preserve. Try several values and seeds; stable patterns still need checks in the original data.

Answer: Reading t-SNE

Read what changed before choosing a setting

Setting	Interpretation
Small perplexity	Local islands appear, even in random data
Larger perplexity	Some islands disappear
Original data	Check neighbors, stability and domain meaning

The setting changes the picture; the underlying data stay fixed

Reading a t-SNE Plot

Check stability; axes, blob areas, and gaps do not directly measure the original geometry

- **The axes carry no meaning.** PCA rotates, so its axes can be read; these two cannot
- **Blob area does not directly measure density.** Dense regions are inflated and sparse ones are shrunk
- **The distance between two clusters is not their dissimilarity.** Local neighborhoods are an approximate optimization target

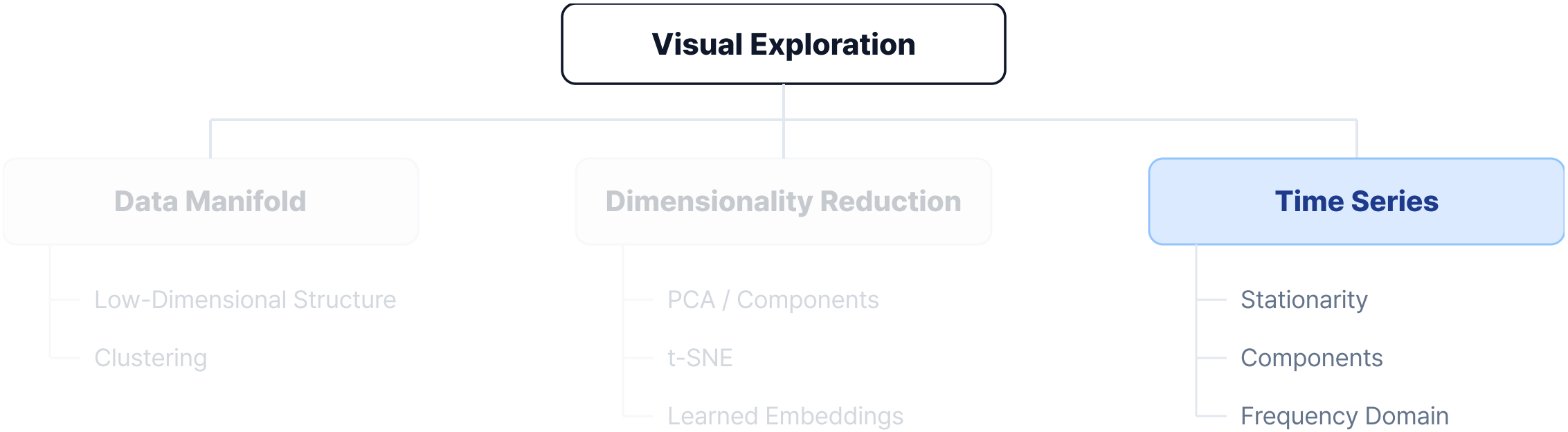
Deep Representation Learning

A network can learn the axes for you: the embedding is learned, not designed



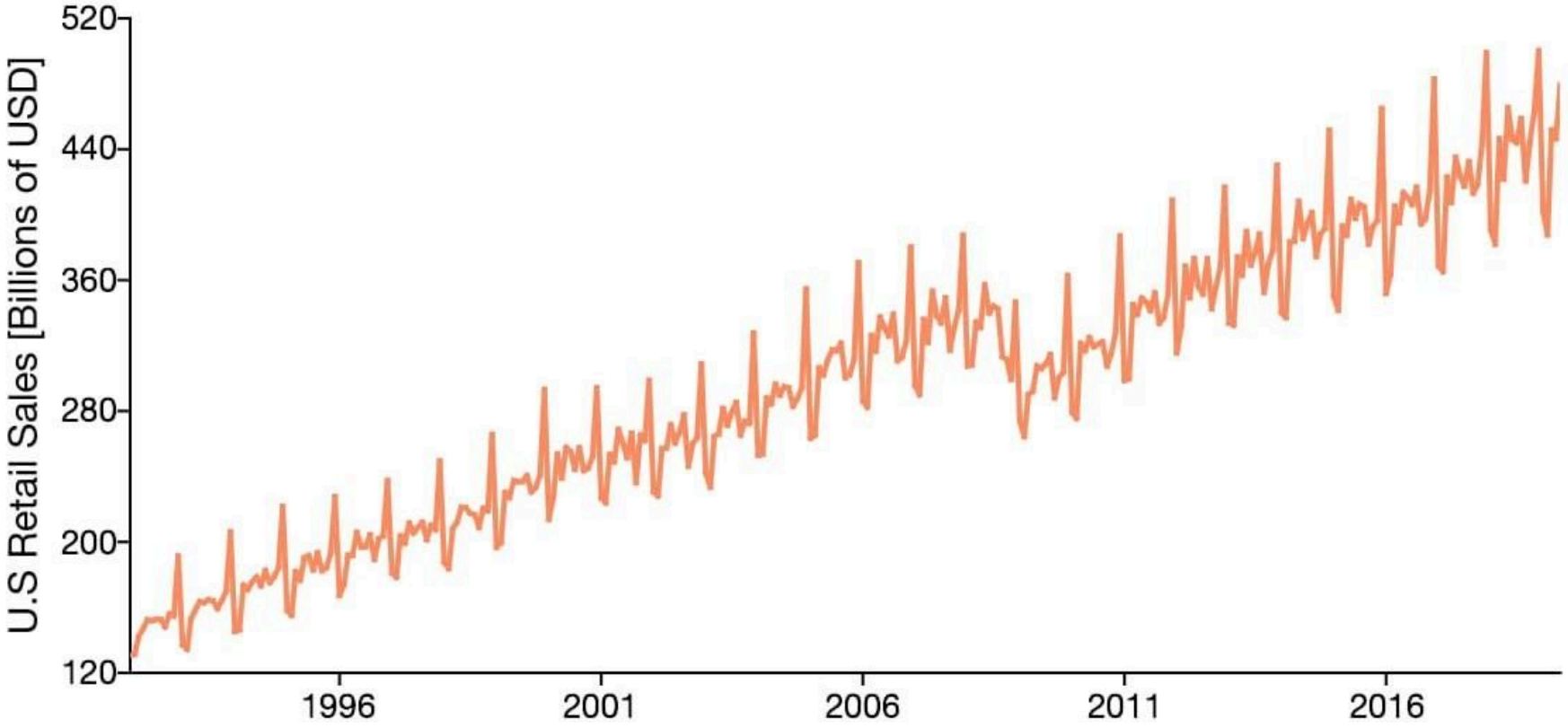
Faces placed near each other really are similar, and **nobody designed the axes**

Time Series


Visual Exploration
Data Manifold
Low-Dimensional Structure
Clustering
Dimensionality Reduction
PCA / Components
t-SNE
Learned Embeddings
Time Series
Stationarity
Components
Frequency Domain

Time Series and Stationarity

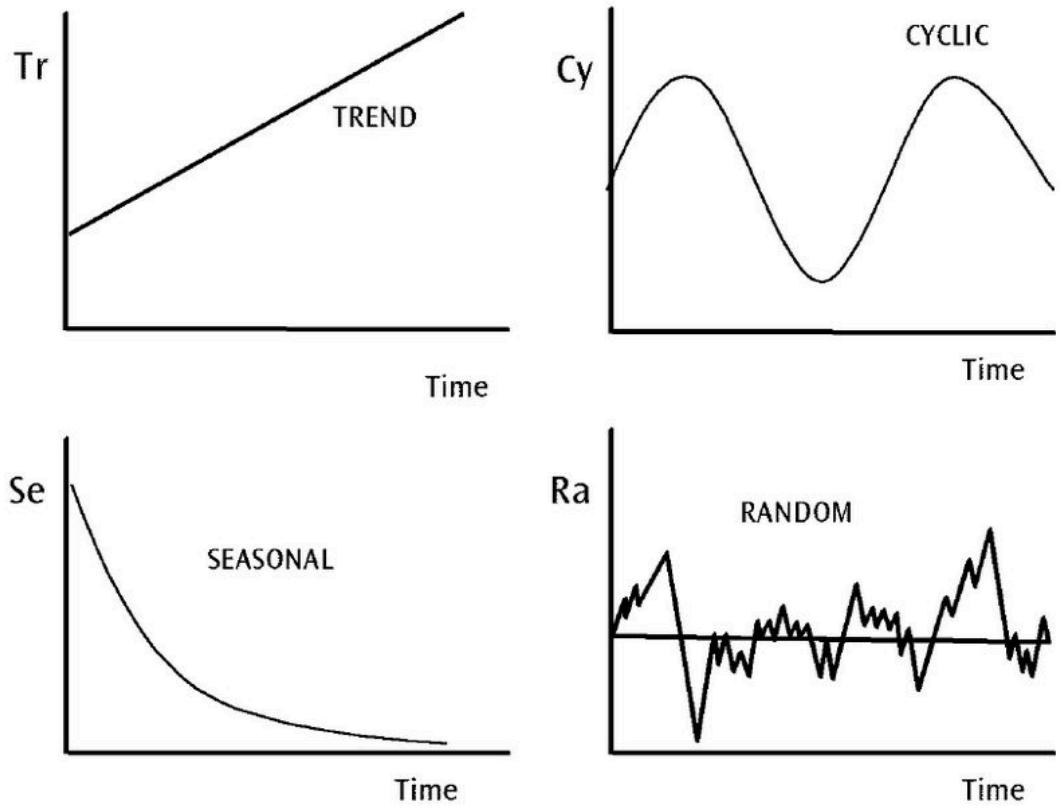
Order, trend, and seasonality contain information that one mean cannot capture



A changing mean violates weak stationarity; a single average hides the trend

Four Components of a Series

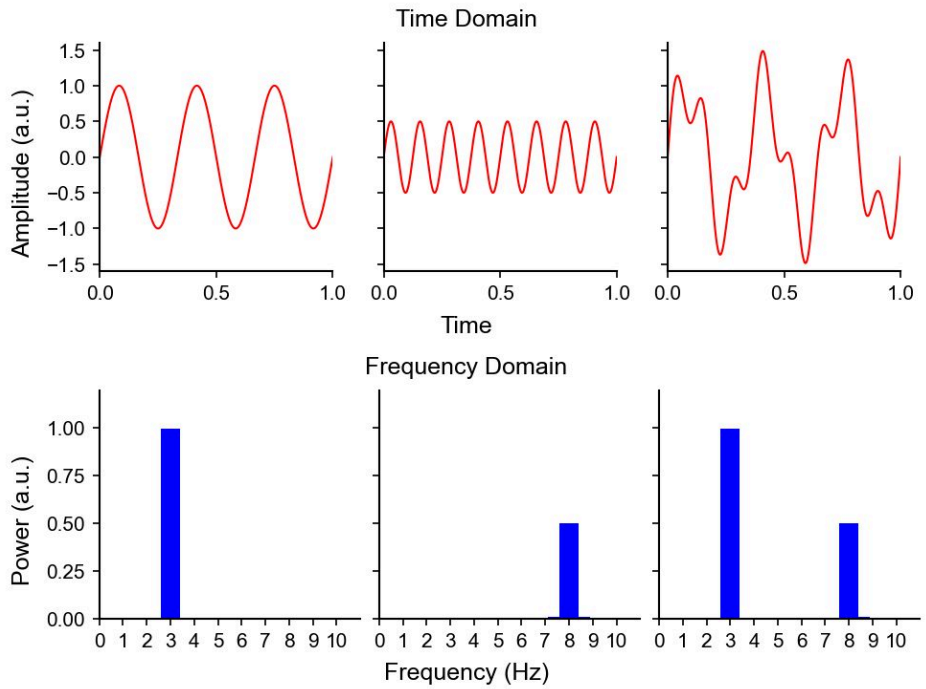
Trend, cyclic, seasonal, random



Seasonal repeats on a **fixed** period. Cyclic does not. That is the whole difference

Time Domain vs Frequency Domain

The same signal: a tangled wave in time becomes two bars in frequency



$$X(f) = \int x(t)\, e^{-2\pi i f t}\, dt$$ the Fourier transform; the fast Fourier transform (FFT) computes it quickly

What looks tangled in time becomes **two bars in frequency**

Statistical Exploration

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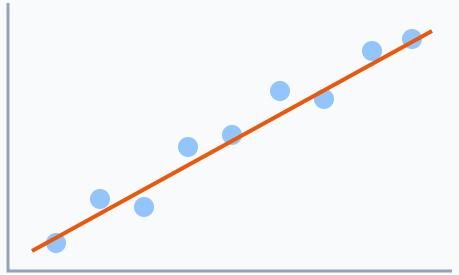
02

Visual Exploration

Find patterns by plotting the data

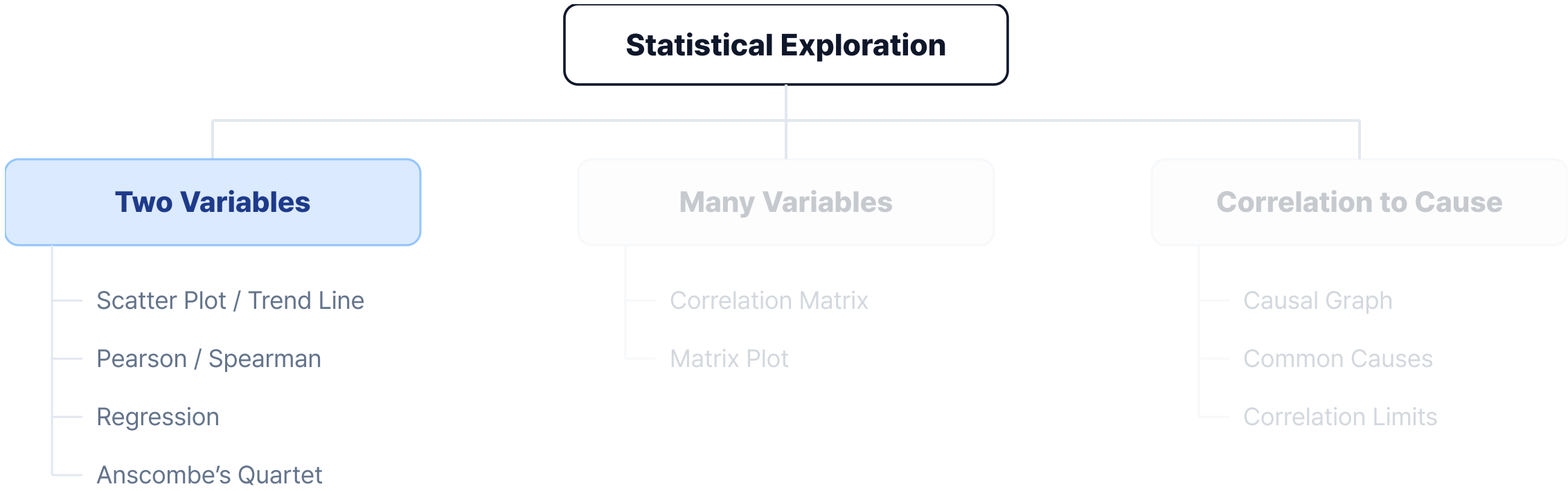
03

Statistical Exploration



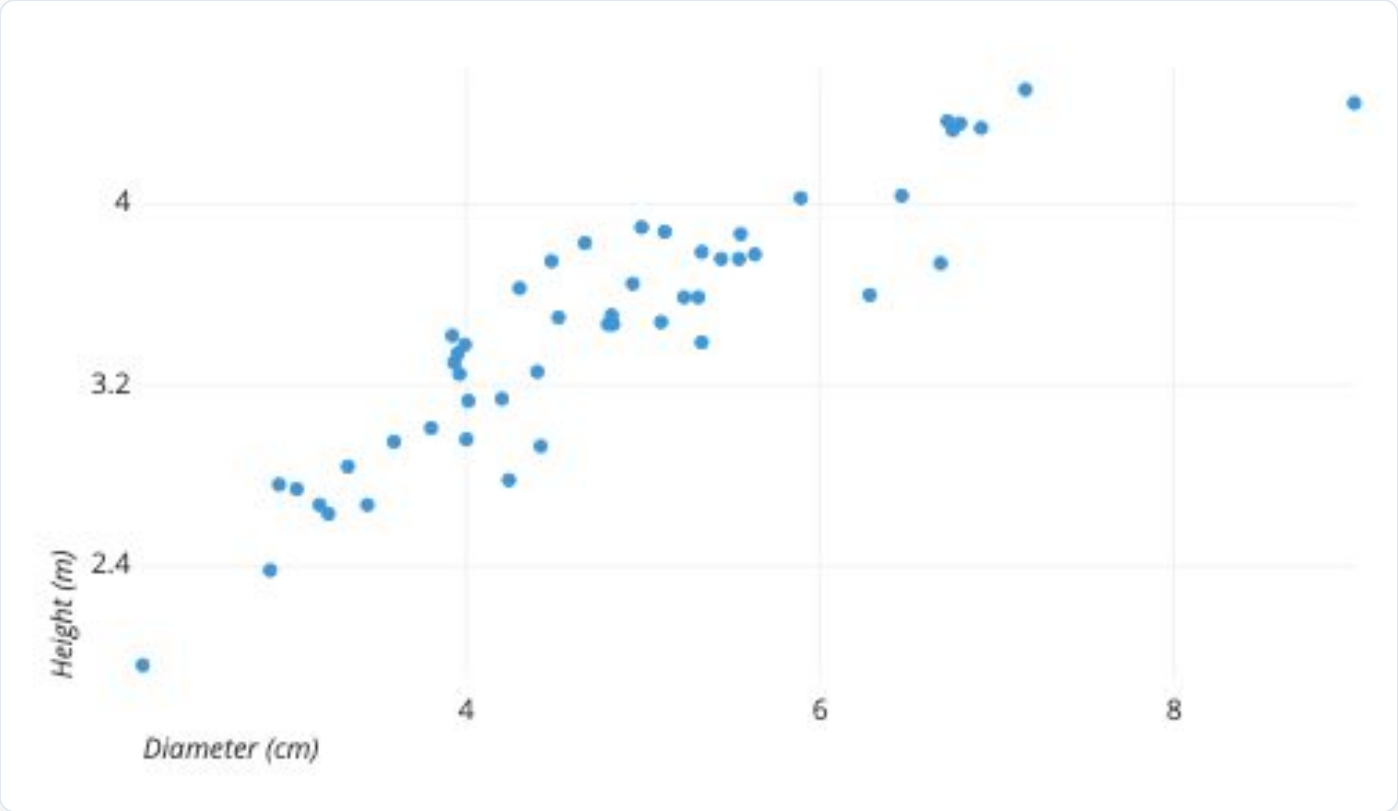
Read relationships between variables

Two Variables



Scatter Plot

Before any number, plot every row: the only two-variable picture that still shows them all



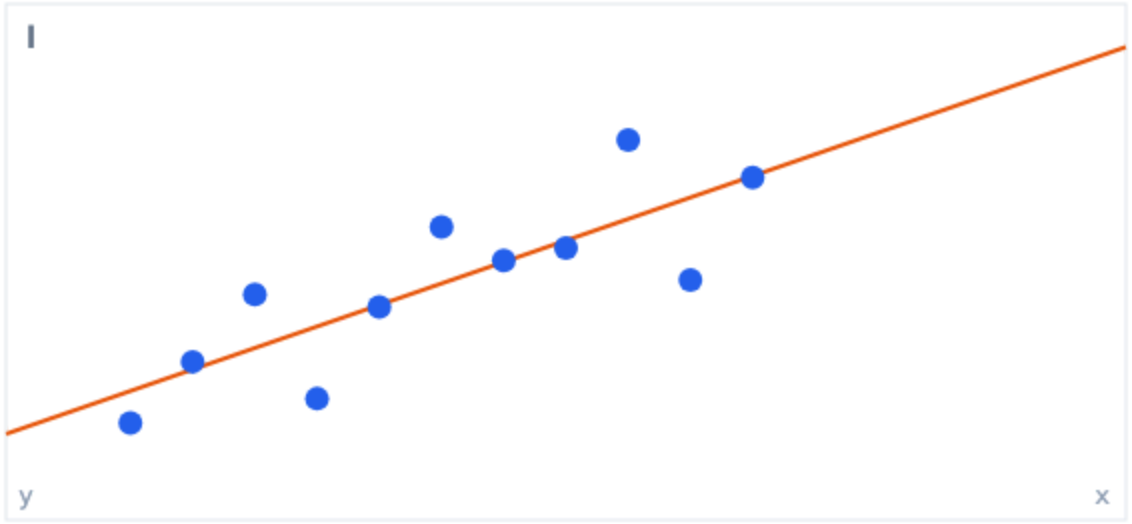
Direction, shape, spread, and the rows that sit apart, **all before anything is computed**

Demo: Anscombe's Quartet

Same mean, same variance, same correlation, same fitted line

1. Do equal summaries imply equal shapes? 2. Which plot makes the fitted line misleading?

I | II | III | IV | All four



mean x **9.00** · sd x **3.32** · mean y **7.50** · sd y **2.03** · r **0.82** · fit **y = 3.00 + 0.50x**

Answer: Anscombe's Quartet

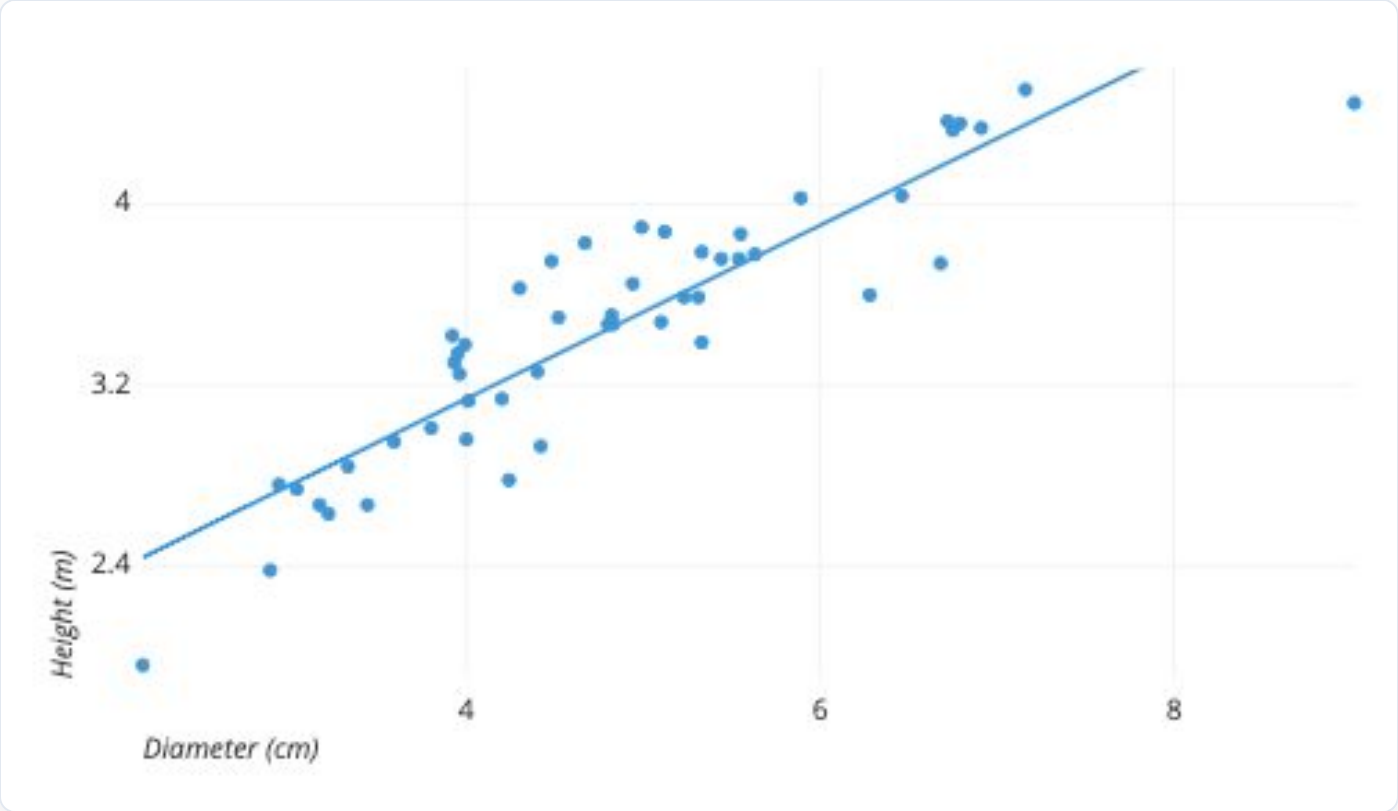
The same summary statistics describe different relationships

What stays the same	What the plots reveal
Mean and spread	Different geometry
Correlation ≈ 0.82	Curve, outlier and leverage
Line y ≈ 3 + 0.50x	A line is not equally informative in every plot

Plot the observations before interpreting a fitted relationship

Fitting a Line

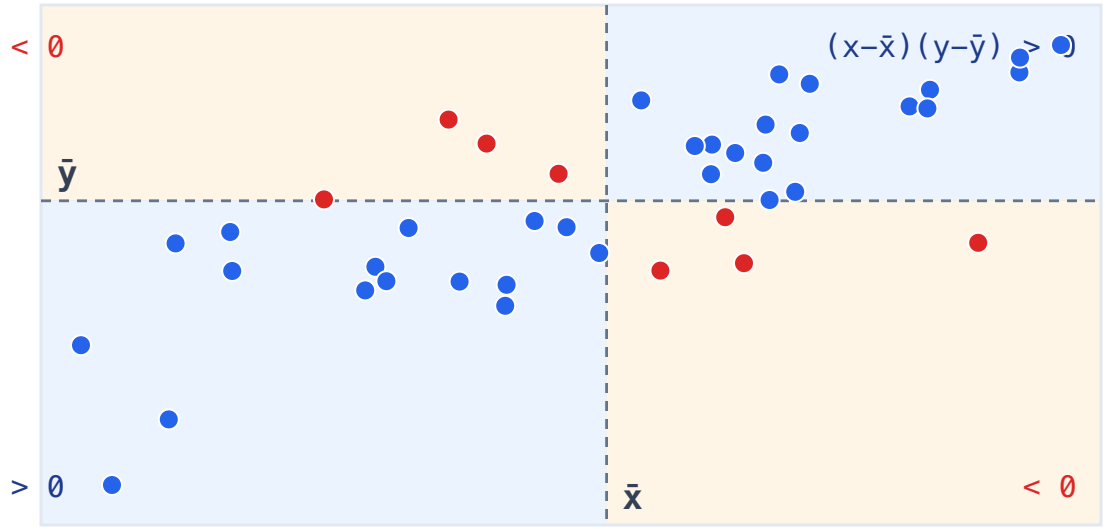
A line summarizes the pair; how tightly the points hug it is what r will measure



Most rows sit close to the line. **The far one became an exception only when the line appeared**

Covariance of Two Columns

Two columns can spread out together, measured in the units of both



one column

$s^2 = \mathrm{cov}(x, x)$

p columns

$\Sigma_{ij} = \mathrm{cov}(x_i, x_j)$

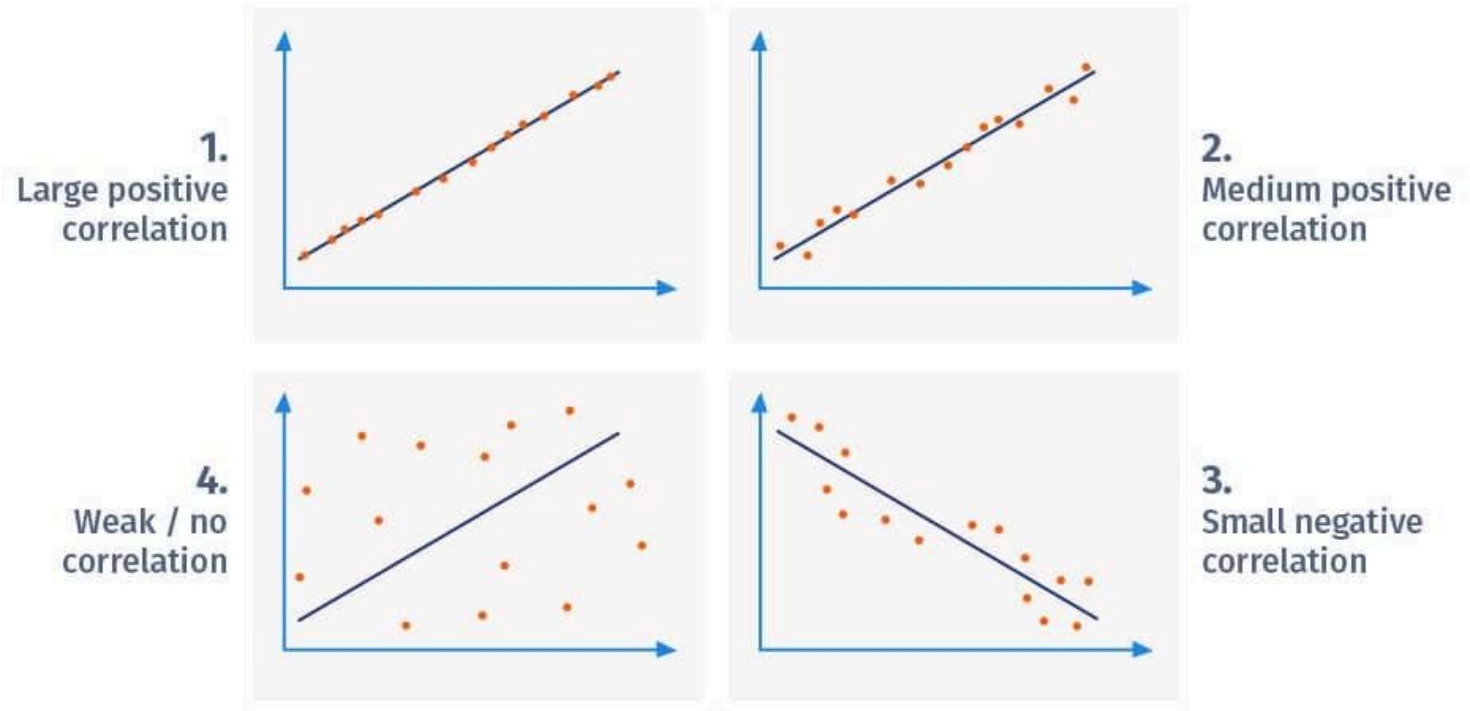
a p × p matrix, s^2 on the diagonal

$\mathrm{cov}(x, y) = (1/(n-1)) \sum_i (x_i - \bar{x})(y_i - \bar{y})$ the SD formula with the second factor taken from another column

Blue points push the sum up and orange points pull it down: **positive covariance means blue outweighs orange**

Pearson Correlation

r measures a straight line, not any relation: a scatter plot reduced to one number

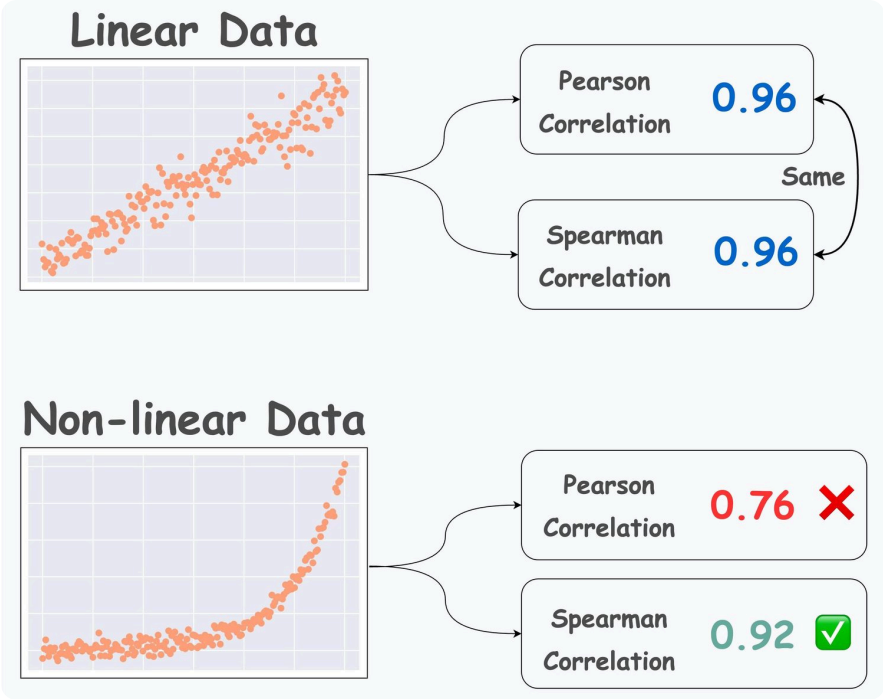


$$r = \sum_i (x_i - \bar{x})(y_i - \bar{y}) \,/\, \sqrt{\left(\sum_i (x_i - \bar{x})^2 \sum_i (y_i - \bar{y})^2\right)}$$ the same thing as $\mathrm{cov}(x, y) / \sigma_x \sigma_y$

Panel 4 still has a line drawn through it. **r near zero means no straight line, not no relation**

Spearman’s Rank Correlation

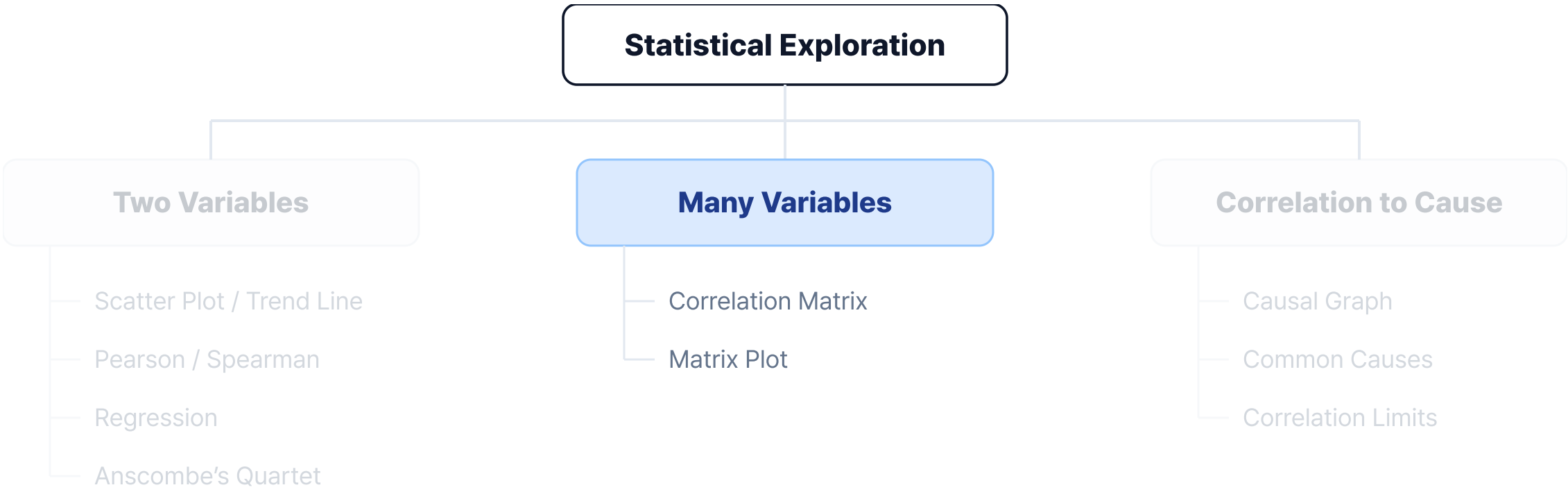
Ranks catch the curve that Pearson underrates: does it keep going one way?



$$\rho = 1 - 6\sum_i d_i^2 \,/\, (n(n^2 - 1))$$ d_i = the gap between row i’s two ranks

Replace each axis with its ranking, then run Pearson. The monotone curve reads **0.76 as Pearson, 0.92 as Spearman**

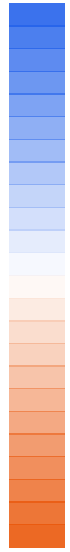
Many Variables



Correlation Matrix

Every pair at once: six process variables, but only two groups of information

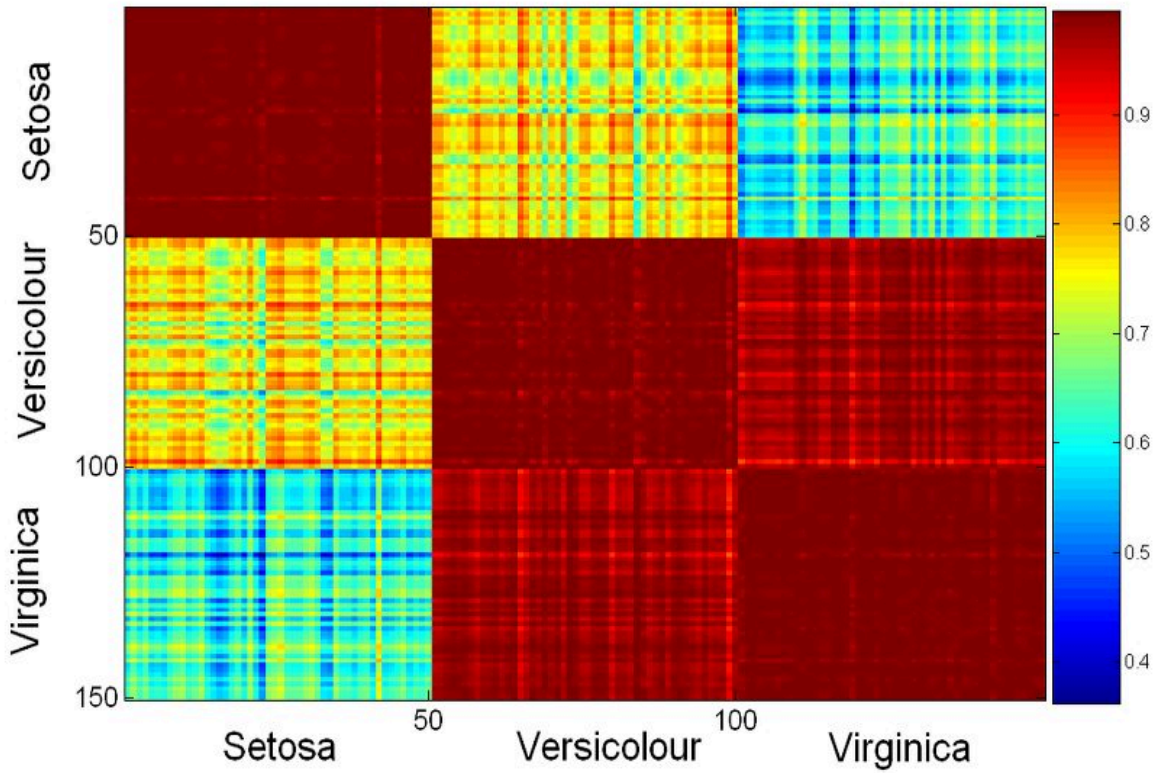
	Speed	Vibration	Temp	Defect	Rework	Humidity
Speed	1.00	0.82	0.81	0.47	0.42	0.08
Vibration	0.82	1.00	0.81	0.40	0.39	0.10
Temp	0.81	0.81	1.00	0.42	0.40	0.12
Defect	0.47	0.40	0.42	1.00	0.76	−0.03
Rework	0.42	0.39	0.40	0.76	1.00	−0.02
Humidity	0.08	0.10	0.12	−0.03	−0.02	1.00



Speed, vibration and temperature **carry almost the same information**

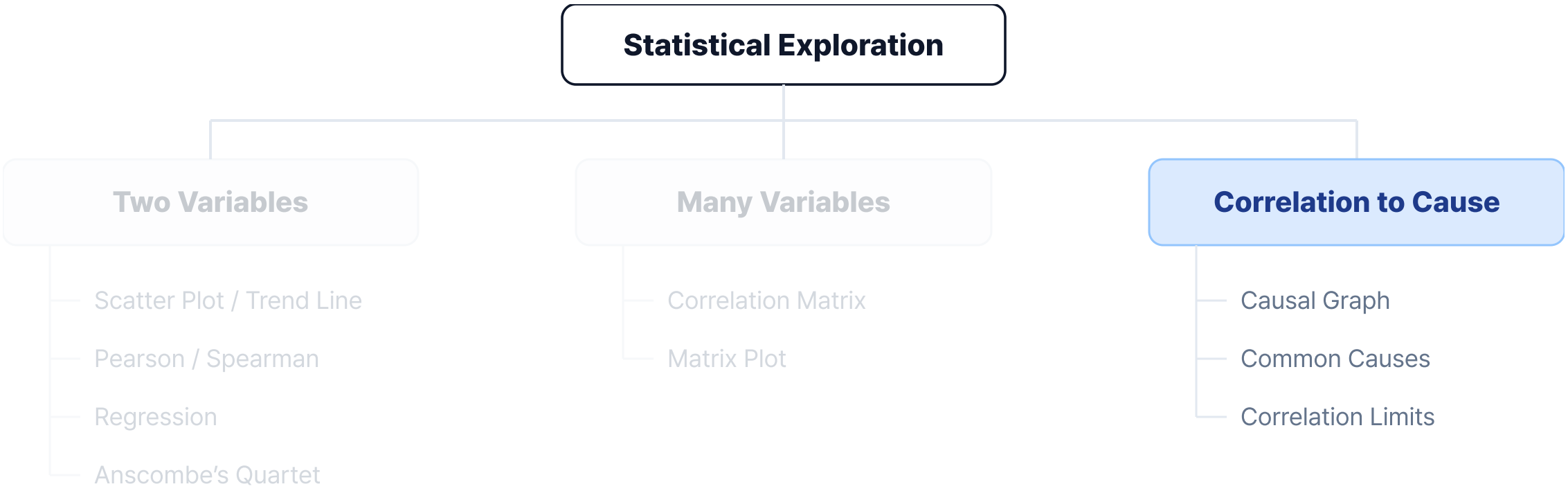
Matrix Plot

Reorder both axes by species and similar samples form blocks along the diagonal



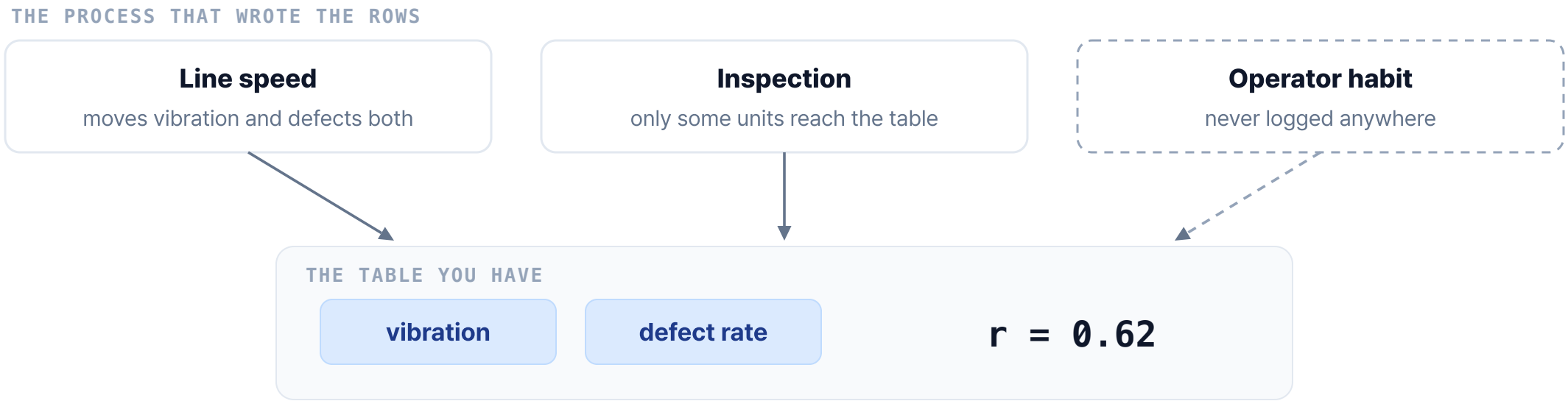
Reordering both axes reveals **similarity blocks** that a random order hides

Correlation to Cause



What wrote this table?

Exploration reads the rows; what the rows mean is decided one level up



The correlation is observed in the table; **its meaning depends on the process above it**

Causal Graphs

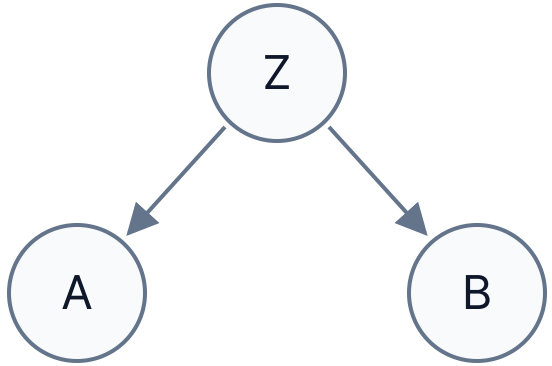
The same correlation can reflect either causal direction or a shared cause



A causes B



B causes A

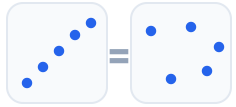


Z causes both

Three structures give one correlation; **the correlation alone cannot tell them apart**

Takeaway: Look before you summarize

Exploration reveals patterns whose meaning depends on measurement and modeling choices



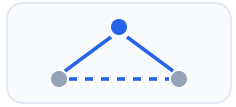
A summary is a lossy compression

Anscombe's datasets share several summary statistics but have different shapes



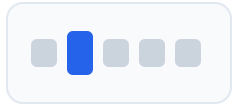
Every tool here hides a choice

Bin width, perplexity, k, and the distribution you assumed



A correlation is a finding, not a causal conclusion

What it means depends on what wrote the table



Explore before you clean

You can only decide what to fix once you know what is strange